

Passages - Orthodoxy

The man who cannot believe his senses, and the man who cannot believe anything else, are both insane, but their insanity is proved not by any error in their argument, but by the manifest mistake of their whole lives. They have both locked themselves up in two boxes, painted inside with the sun and stars; they are both unable to get out, the one into the health and happiness of heaven, the other even into the health and happiness of the earth.

The morbid logician seeks to make everything lucid, and succeeds in making everything mysterious. The mystic allows one thing to be mysterious, and everything else becomes lucid.

Humility was largely meant as a restraint upon the arrogance and infinity of the appetite of man. He was always outstripping his mercies with his own newly invented needs. His very power of enjoyment destroyed half his joys. By asking for pleasure, he lost the chief pleasure; for the chief pleasure is surprise.

It is impossible without humility to enjoy anything -even pride.

All the will-worshippers, from Nietzsche to Mr. Davidson, are really quite empty of volition. They cannot will, they can hardly wish. They always talk of will as something that expands and breaks out. But it is quite the opposite. Every act of will is an act of self-limitation. To desire action is to desire limitation. In that sense every act is an act of self-sacrifice. When you choose anything, you reject everything else.

Art is limitation; the essence of every picture is the frame. If you draw a giraffe, you must draw him with a long neck. If, in your bold creative way, you hold yourself free to draw a giraffe with a short neck, you will really find that you are not free to draw a giraffe. The moment you step into the world of facts, you step into a world of limits. This is certainly the case with all artistic creation, which is in some ways the most decisive example of pure will. The artist loves his limitations: they constitute the **THING** he is doing. The painter is glad that the canvas is flat. The sculptor is glad that the clay is colourless.

The modern revolutionist, being an infinite sceptic, is always engaged in undermining his own mines. In his book on politics he attacks men for trampling on morality; in his book on ethics he attacks morality for trampling on men. The modern man in revolt has become practically useless for all purposes of revolt. By rebelling against everything he has lost his right to rebel against anything.

Every man who will not have softening of the heart must at last have softening of the brain.

It is no argument for unalterable law (as Huxley fancied) that we count on the ordinary course of things. We do not count on it; we bet on it.

The ordinary scientific man is strictly a sentimentalist. He is a sentimentalist in this essential sense, that he is soaked and swept away by mere associations.

Economy is far more romantic than extravagance.

The evil of the pessimist is, then, not that he chastises gods and men, but that he does not love what he chastises- he has not this primary and supernatural loyalty to things. What is the evil of the man commonly called an optimist? The optimist, wishing to defend the honour of this world, will defend the in-defensible. He is the jingo of the universe; he will say, "My cosmos right or wrong." He will be less inclined to the reform of things; soothing every one with assurances. He will not wash the world, but white wash the world.

Rational optimism leads to stagnation: it is irrational optimism that leads to reform. The man who is most likely to ruin the place he loves is exactly the man who loves it with a reason. The man who will improve the place is the man who loves it without a reason.

The man who kills himself, kills all men; as far as he is concerned he wipes out the world. The thief compliments the things he steals, if not the owner of them. But the suicide insults everything on earth by not stealing it.

An unselfish egoist is a man who has pride without the excuse of passion.

The mere pursuit of health always leads to something unhealthy. Physical nature must not be made the direct object of obedience; it must be enjoyed, not worshipped.

All creation is separation. Birth is as solemn a parting as death.

Everywhere in things there is this element of the quiet and incalculable. It escapes

the rationalists, but it never escapes till the last moment.

The more complicated seems the coincidence, the less it can be a coincidence

Man was only sad because he was not a beast, but a broken god.

We must be much more angry with theft than before, and yet much kinder to thieves than before.

There never was anything so perilous or so exciting as orthodoxy. It was sanity: and to be sane is more dramatic than to be mad. It was the equilibrium of a man behind madly rushing horses, seeming to stoop this way and to sway that, yet in every attitude having the grace of statuary and the accuracy of arithmetic.

It is always simple to fall; there are an infinity of angles at which one falls, only one at which one stands.

Mere resignation has neither the gigantic levity of pleasure nor the superb intolerance of pain. If you merely bear it, you do not grin. Greek heroes do not grin: but gargoyles do- because they are Christian.

We have said we must be fond of this world, even in order to change it. We now add that we must be fond of another world (real or imaginary) in order to have something to change it to.

The modern young man will never change his environment; for he will always change his mind.

The perfect happiness of men on the earth (if it ever comes) will not be a flat and solid thing, like the satisfaction of animals. It will be an exact and perilous balance; like that of a desperate romance. Man must have just enough faith in himself to have adventures, and just enough doubt of himself to enjoy them.

The only real reason for being a progressive is that things naturally tend to grow worse.

We have not got to crown the exceptional man who knows he can rule. Rather we must crown the much more exceptional man who knows he can't.

The swiftest things are the softest things.

The rich man is bribed; he has been bribed already. That is why he is a rich man.

Seriousness is not a virtue. It would be a heresy, but a much more sensible heresy, to say that seriousness is a vice. It is really a natural trend or lapse into taking one's self gravely, because it is the easiest thing to do. For solemnity flows out of men naturally; but laughter is a leap. It is easy to be heavy: hard to be light.

I could never conceive or tolerate any Utopia which did not leave to me the liberty for which I chiefly care, the liberty to bind myself.

How can it be noble to wish to make one's life infinite and yet mean to wish to make it immortal?

The Buddhist is looking with a peculiar intentness inwards. The Christian is staring with a frantic intentness outwards.

Love desires personality; therefore love desires division.

All moral reform must start in the active not the passive will.

The secularists have not wrecked divine things; but the secularists have wrecked secular things, if that is any comfort to them. The Titans did not scale heaven; but they laid waste the world.

We talk of wild animals; man is the only wild animal. It is man that has broken out.

The very time when I was most under a woman's authority, I was most full of flame and adventure.

Christianity preaches an obviously unattractive idea, such as original sin; but when we wait for its results, they are pathos and brother-hood, and a thunder of laughter and pity; for only with original sin we can at once pity the beggar and distrust the king. Men of science offer us health, an obvious benefit; it is only afterwards that we discover that by health, they mean bodily slavery and spiritual tedium. The strongest argument for the divine grace is simply its ungraciousness

Danger is the root of all drama and romance.

Everything human must have in it both joy and sorrow; the only matter of interest is the manner in which the two things are balanced or divided.

Man is more himself, man is more manlike, when joy is the fundamental thing in him, and grief the superficial. Melancholy

should be an innocent interlude, a tender and fugitive frame of mind; praise should be the permanent pulsation the soul.